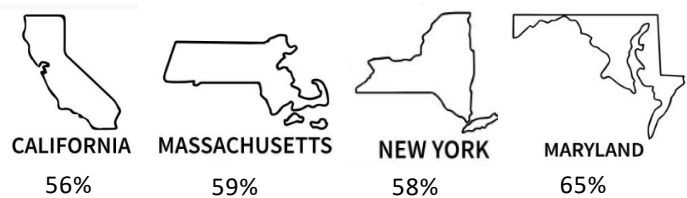
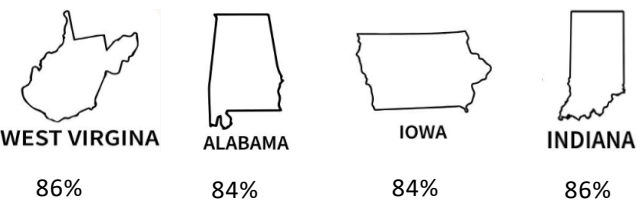


How far does Social Security Go? Comparing Benefits to Elder Index 2025

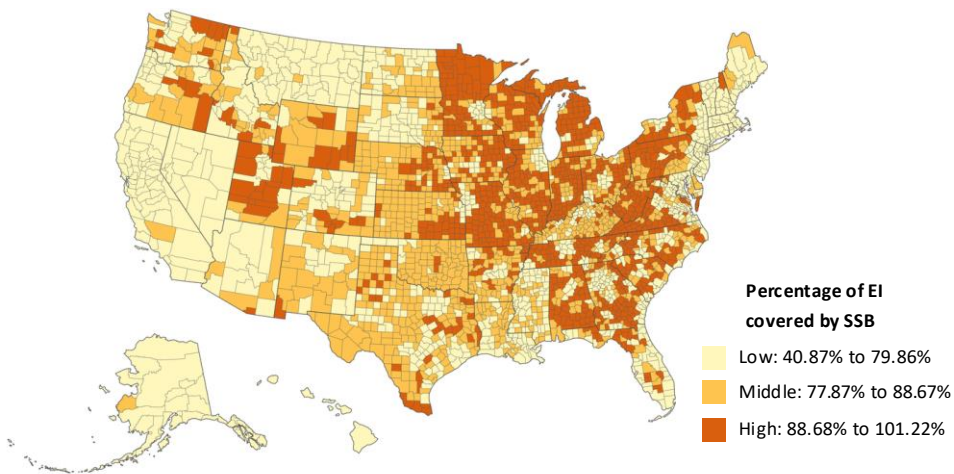
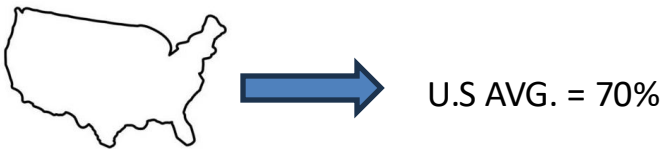
- Average Social Security benefits cover only **70%** of necessary living expenses for single older renters nationwide, while benefits cover about 78% for older couple renters.
- Homeowners without a mortgage have the most coverage by SSB (91%)



Four states where Social Security benefits cover the **LEAST** amount of Elder Index for single older renters



Four states where Social Security benefits cover the **MOST** amount of Elder Index for single older renters



- Counties in California, the Northeast, and parts of Florida continue to show lower relative coverage even for couples.
- Counties with the lowest coverage levels are concentrated in:
 - California → High-cost metro regions
 - Northeast → Parts of the Mountain West
- Regional disparities are **more** pronounced for single older renters than for older couples.

Coverage of U.S. Elder Index by average Social Security benefits, 2015 and 2025

	Single living alone	Couples living together
2025		
Elder Index	\$34,032	\$47,016
Average SSB	\$23,704	\$36,703
% of Index covered by SSB	69.7%	78.1%
Amount uncovered	\$10,328	\$10,313
2015		
Elder Index	\$23,088	\$33,504
Average SSB	\$15,943	\$26,009
% of Index covered by SSB	69.1%	77.6%
Amount uncovered	\$7,145	\$7,495

Then vs. Now: 2015 → 2025

- **Covered:** 69% → 69.7%
- **Uncovered:** \$7,145 → \$10,328
- The gap between Social Security income and the Elder Index has remained largely unchanged over the past decade, despite annual COLA increases.
- Older renters face an average annual shortfall of more than \$10,000 between Social Security income and basic living costs.

Social Security remains the foundation of retirement income, but for millions of older adults it does not fully cover the cost of basic necessities such as housing, health care, food, and transportation.

UMass Boston

Learn more about the
Elder Index: elderindex.org
Gerontology Institute,
Manning College of Nursing & Health Sciences
csdra@umb.edu

Table 2. Coverage of U.S. Elder Index by average Social Security benefits, 2015 and 2025		
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SOURCES:

- Elder Index. (2025). The Elder Index™ [Public Dataset]. Boston, MA: Gerontology Institute, University of Massachusetts Boston. See <https://elderindex.org/>
- Social Security benefit:
https://www.ssa.gov/policy/docs/statcomps/oasdi_sc/index.html

NOTE: All values assume renters are in good health.

SSB = Social Security benefits. Coverage is defined as the percentage of the Elder Index fulfilled by the average Social Security benefit in the United States.